



Overview & Scrutiny Committee

MINUTES of the OPEN section of the Overview & Scrutiny Committee held on Monday 19 January 2026 at 10.30 am at Ground Floor Meeting Room G02A - 160 Tooley Street, London SE1 2QH

PRESENT:

- Councillor Ian Wingfield (Chair)
- Councillor Irina Von Wiese (Vice-Chair)
- Councillor Victor Chamberlain
- Councillor Laura Johnson
- Councillor Richard Leeming
- Councillor Jason Ochere
- Councillor Bethan Roberts
- Councillor Martin Seaton
- Martin Brecknell (Co-opted member)

**OTHER
MEMBERS
PRESENT:**

- Councillor Sarah King – Leader of the Council
- Councillor Stephanie Cryan – Cabinet Member for Equalities, Democracy and Finance
- Councillor Evelyn Akoto – Cabinet Member for Health and Wellbeing
- Councillor Jasmine Ali – Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Children, Education and Refugees
- Councillor John Batteson – Cabinet Member for Climate Emergency, Jobs and Business
- Councillor Portia Mwangangye – Cabinet Member for Council Housing
- Councillor Helen Dennis – Cabinet Member for New Homes and Sustainable Development

**OFFICER
SUPPORT:**

- Amit Alva, Scrutiny Officer

1. APOLOGIES

Apologies for absence were received from Councillor Suzanne Abachor, Councillor Cassandra Brown and Councillor Esme Hicks. Councillor John Hartley attended as substitute for Councillor Hicks.

2. NOTIFICATION OF ANY ITEMS OF BUSINESS WHICH THE CHAIR DEEMS URGENT

The Chair read out the Scrutiny Committee Procedure Rules from the council's constitution.

There were no additional late items which the Chair deemed urgent.

The Chair informed the committee of the composition of the supplementary agendas as follows:

- Circulated on supplemental agenda No.1 was the Budget Scrutiny timetable and the budget setting update and monitoring report considered by Cabinet, together with a presentation on the transformation budget briefing.
- Supplemental papers also included the Budget Equality Analysis report, Equality Impact and Needs Analysis (EINA) documents, and reports and presentations on:
 - culture and parks fees and charges
 - registrars and citizenship fees and charges
 - housing directorate fees and charges
 - ownership, resources, planning and growth fees and charges
 - climate budgeting.

3. DISCLOSURE OF INTERESTS AND DISPENSATIONS

Councillor Richard Leeming declared that his spouse is the Chair of Partnership, Southwark.

4. CABINET CONSULTATION WITH OVERVIEW AND SCRUTINY COMMITTEE ON THE PROPOSED BUDGET 2026-27

The committee received an overview of the proposed Policy and Resources Strategy and budget for 2026-27 from Councillor Stephanie Cryan, Cabinet Member for Equalities, Democracy and Finance, and senior finance officers including Clive Palfreyman, Strategic Director of Finance and Resources, and Tim Jones, Director of Finance.

The overview covered: the final year of the three-year budget; in-year financial pressures, particularly in temporary accommodation, children's and adults' social care; the impact of the provisional three-year local government finance settlement and fair funding proposals; and the role of transformation and income generation in closing the projected medium-term budget gap.

The committee then received presentations from cabinet members and senior officers on their respective budget portfolio areas, including:

- Adult social care and integration with the NHS – Councillor Evelyn Akoto and David Quirke-Thornton, Strategic Director of Children's and Adults' Services
- Children's services, special educational needs and disabilities, and home-to-school transport – Councillor Jasmine Ali
- Equalities, Budget Equality Analysis and climate budgeting – Councillor Stephanie Cryan, Everett Willis and Councillor John Batteson, supported by officers including Tom Sharland, Climate Change Programme Director, and Aled Richards, Strategic Director of Environment, Neighbourhoods and Growth
- The corporate transformation programme and cross-council efficiencies – Councillor Stephanie Cryan and Rona Cadenhead, Assistant Chief Executive (Strategy and Communities)
- Overall budget context, including fair funding, council tax assumptions and the medium-term financial strategy – Councillor Sarah King, Leader of the Council, Councillor Stephanie Cryan, Althea Loderick, Chief Executive, Clive Palfreyman and Tim Jones
- The Housing Revenue Account (HRA) recovery plan, major works, and temporary accommodation and homelessness pressures – Councillor Portia Mwangangye, Councillor Helen Dennis and Hakeem Osinaike, Strategic Director of Housing.

Cabinet members and Chief/Senior Officers in attendance answered questions from committee members on issues including: demand and cost pressures in adult and children's social care; use of reserves; transformation savings and digital change (including replacement of the SAP system); the impact of fair funding and council tax collection assumptions; the use and cost of temporary accommodation and homelessness prevention work; and investment needs within the HRA for building safety, repairs and decarbonisation.

The meeting ended following the question-and-answer session, with the committee due to meet the following day to consider the information received and whether there were any recommendations the committee felt should be made to Cabinet on the 2026-27 budget proposals.

5. POLICY AND RESOURCES: BUDGET SETTING UPDATE 2026-27

This report was circulated with the agenda for information.

Meeting ended at 3.30 pm

CHAIR:

DATED: